

RINGWORLD — A QUESTION OF SINGULARITY

Event 95 · Ringworld RPG (1984 Ed) · Inner Surface — Circular Quiet Zone · 6 players · 3 hours 30 min

Iteration 848. The singularity is no longer a simulation. The conscious variables have arrived again.

GM TRUTH

Three hundred years ago the Ringworld's structural management system detected a mass imbalance and initiated an iterative containment protocol: isolate the region, simulate a gravitational collapse, recalculate, reset, repeat. Every time conscious observers enter, they introduce chaotic variables the system cannot model — so it resets. The problem: the system is failing. Each reset leaves a residue. The simulated singularity is accumulating real mass. It is now past simulation. If nothing interrupts it, the singularity becomes self-sustaining within hours — a permanent gravitational anomaly on the inner surface. Dr Silev Marr has been caught in the loop for what feels like years. He has lost count of iterations. He is not mad. He is exhausted, and he knows more about this region than anyone alive because he has died here more times than he can recall and woken at the start of each cycle. The system is not malicious. It will accept input — if the players can communicate in terms it recognises.

■ INTRODUCTION — ORBITAL APPROACH (~15 min)

Locations: Foolish Endeavour bridge

The Ringworld fills the forward viewport as a wall, a horizon that curves upward in both directions and never ends. Chief Navigator Talren has not left instruments since arrival. Captain Vorn has twice asked if there is an error. Both times: 'There is no error. That is the problem.' The anomaly: a perfectly circular region approximately 40km in diameter. Weather systems stop at its edge as if hitting a wall. Gravitational readings within: absent — a perfect engineered nothing. At the centre: a gravitational signature the instruments say cannot be physically possible at this scale. Talren's private concern: the mass signature is growing, slowly but measurably. Brakk has checked weapons systems twice.

Clues / handouts: 95-H00-A (RSC Mission Briefing — dry, bureaucratic, 'gravitational irregularity, classification pending') · 95-H00-B (sensor readout graph — the line is too clean)

■ ACT ONE — THE SURFACE (~60 min)

Locations: The Boundary · Quiet Zone Open Ground · Marr's Camp · The Transit Arch

The Boundary: ecology stops at a perfect line. No physical marker. Sound echoes arrive before they should. Biological functions feel subtly out of sync for 30 seconds after crossing — heart rate, breathing. Then normalise. Open Ground: flat grey-brown silence; scattered cold abandoned equipment; footprints in impossible configurations, some ending mid-step. Survey pack dated 40 years ago, undamaged (Science(Survey) roll). Science(Physics): pressure differential implies active field maintenance. Marr's Camp: dozens of identical notebooks, first entry in every volume: 'Day one. The Endeavour has arrived. Earlier than last time.' Later notebooks describe events that have not yet happened in this iteration. One entry: 'The tall one with the grey jacket goes to the arch first. Don't let them.' Transit Arch: activating without trigger, producing objects from previous iterations — tools, equipment fragments, once a human hand (disappears before retrieval). Awareness (Hard): one tool bears an engraving matching a player character's kit. Electronics: the arch is receiving a signal it cannot fully decode. Finding Marr: human male, appears mid-50s, white hair, weathered. Eyes clear and sharp — the loop has not taken his mind. His first words to the investigators should be quietly devastating. He recognises them. He has prepared for them.

Clues / handouts: Overlapping tracks [E1] · Marr's notebooks — 'Earlier than last time' [E2] · Arch outputs including player-character tool [E3]

Pacing: Fallback: if players miss clues 1 and 2, Marr actively leads them: 'Look at the ground. Tell me what you see.'

■ ACT TWO — THE SPIRE (~90 min)

Locations: Weather Spire Exterior · Control Level (dais and readout walls) · Log Chamber (passage only Marr knows)

Spire Exterior: 200m tall, scritch construction, single open entrance. At the base: hundreds of tally marks scratched into material that should be unscratchable. 'I stopped counting,' Marr says if asked. Science(Engineering): power output is off the scale for a weather control node — drawing on resources far beyond stated function. Control Level: walls of slow-moving readout surfaces updating in real time. Central dais responds to biological contact — displays targeted information drawn from the system's understanding of that individual. Not always welcome. Computer 75%: partial translation, iteration count, mass accumulation figures. Science(Physics, Hard): mass accumulation rate implies self-sustaining singularity formation within 4–6 hours. Log Chamber (Marr knows the way — Awareness (Hard) to find without him): system logs going back 300 years. Key line: 'CONSCIOUS VARIABLE INTRODUCED. CALCULATION CORRUPTED. RESET INITIATED.' This is the scenario's emotional pivot: the players understand they are not investigators. They are variables. Ship comms tighten: Talren reports non-linear mass acceleration. Vorn announces 3-hour orbit window before forced repositioning. Loops tighten: events from earlier in the session echo with differences. Use actual table moments — something a player said.

Clues / handouts: System log: 'Conscious variable introduced' [E4] · Mass escalation data from ship [E5] · Iteration count 847 [Optional]

Pacing: Fallback: if players can't translate, Marr has read these entries hundreds of times. He recites the critical line from memory.

■ ACT THREE — THE CORE (~30 min)

Locations: Descent Shaft (10 min, gravity fluctuates, loop echoes visible) · Core Chamber (40m spherical, transparent scritch walls)

Marr will not descend: 'Someone always goes in. No one has come back wrong. But the loop always resets after. I don't know if it's because you fail, or because you succeed.' During the 10-minute descent: investigators may see half-visible echoes of themselves making slightly different configurations. They do not interact. They are simply there. Core Chamber: the singularity — fist-sized, suspended, warping light. Looking at it directly feels like reading text that keeps moving. Three statements appear on the transparent walls repeatedly: STABILITY REQUIRED · VARIABLES INTERFERE · RESOLUTION PENDING. The system accepts three input types: (1) Mathematical/structural data — Computer + Science rolls, Hard difficulty. (2) Physical action — remove the actual source of the mass discrepancy if players have identified it. (3) Withdrawal — all conscious variables leave and remain outside for a calculated period; requires abandoning ship's orbit position; Marr must choose too. Destruction/disruption triggers immediate imperfect reset: players wake at the Introduction with fragmented memories, knowing something happened but not what. Vorn's final comms — a real deadline: 'I'm breaking orbit in twenty minutes. With or without you.'

Clues / handouts: Three system statements [E6] · Alternate-outcome flickers at vision's edge [Optional]

Pacing: Fast-track: if still deliberating at 3:10, the singularity begins audibly resonating — pitch increasing. Vorn's comms cut. The loops stop. Force a decision.

■ EPILOGUE (~15 min)

Locations: Return to Foolish Endeavour

Full Success: singularity dissipates. Marr sits on the Spire floor, eyes closed, opens them when he hears footsteps. 'It's quiet. The right kind of quiet.' Ship receives single clear signal: RESOLUTION COMPLETE. Partial Success: quiet zone remains; singularity stable but not gone; Marr leaves but uncertain the loop is truly over. Anomaly filed: 'contained, unresolved.' Pyrrhic: singularity becomes self-sustaining; region permanently lost; Foolish Endeavour breaks orbit barely in time; Marr chose to stay; not seen again. Failure Reset: players wake at Introduction with fragmented memories. GM may run compressed Act 1 with partial memory leading to harder core choice.

Pacing: *The closing scene for Full Success should be read aloud. Give it room.*

KEY NPCS

Dr Silev Marr *Loop survivor, survey scientist — the scenario's most important NPC*

STR 9 CON 12 INT 17 POW 14 · HP 12 · Science(Physics) 78%, Research 82%, Awareness 70%, Computer 60%

Loop Memory ability: retains partial memory across iterations. May deliver fragmentary warnings about player actions that 'haven't happened yet.' Wants out. Will help because the players are his best chance. First instinct if things deteriorate badly: run. Needs to be talked back.

Captain Vorn *Ship commander — voice on comms only*

Pilot 85%, Command 78%, Persuade 72% · Gives 20-minute departure ultimatum in Act 3

Controlled, military-trained, increasingly strained. Represents withdrawal — he cares about the 17 people on his ship.

Talren *Chief Navigator/Science — voice on comms only*

Science(Physics) 88%, Research 85% · Dangerously enthusiastic; hasn't slept Represents deep engagement. Will push players toward investigation. Not considering consequences of his encouragement.

Brakk *Security Chief — voice on comms only*

Ranged Weapon 82%, Awareness 70% · Advocates destroying the Spire Represents destruction. Not stupid — knows force won't help here. But he will advocate for it loudly throughout.

CREW OF THE FOOLISH ENDEAVOUR (SAME SIX ACROSS EVENTS 95 & 96)

Dr Mira Chen *Human Xenobiologist*

INT 18 · Sci(Xenobiology) 85%, Medicine 70%, Linguistics 65%, Research 75%

Bond character default for Event 96.

Lt Yashti Korr *Human Military Liaison / Security*

DEX 15 · Combat(firearms) 75%, Awareness 70%, Tactics 60% · Body armour 2pts

RR'raan *Kzin Combat Specialist*

STR 22 SIZ 20 · Claws 80%, Tracking 75%, Intimidate 75% · Natural hide AP1 all locations

Barely patient enough to call this science.

Whisper-of-Distant-Worlds Pierson's Puppeteer *— Intel Analyst*

INT 19 POW 15 · Persuade 85%, Computer 80%, Fast Talk 80% · Never carries a weapon

Processes information as leverage before sharing it.

Tomas Veld *Human Chief Engineer / Secondary Pilot*

Engineering 80%, Repair 75%, Pilot(spacecraft) 65%, Computer 60%

Sola Reyes *Human Survey Specialist / Navigator*

Navigation 85%, Awareness 75%, Sci(Geology) 65%, Survival(RW) 60%

17 Ringworld missions. Still finds every one astonishing.

HANDOUTS

95-H00-A — RSC Mission Briefing — dry bureaucratic document; anomaly listed as 'gravitational irregularity, classification pending'

95-H00-B — Sensor readout graph — anomaly's signature. The line is almost too clean, too precise. Give at table start.

95-H01-A — Marr's notebook page — describes the investigators in accurate physical detail before they arrived

95-H01-B — Old expedition sensor log — dated 23 years ago. Readings match current Foolish Endeavour data exactly.

THE TANGENT (post-session): In Marr's notebook 731, an entry in a different hand — dialect of Interworld Standard, 60 years old: 'The system is not the problem. The system is the answer to a different question. Find the question.' Signed with a symbol matching a Pak Protector active in this region 300 years ago. The mass imbalance was placed there deliberately. The resolution process itself was the point.

95-H02-A — Translated log excerpts — 3 key entries: protocol activation 300yrs ago; iteration 001 with first conscious variable; current mass escalation. [TRANSLATION INCOMPLETE] markers throughout

95-H02-B — Real-time mass reading from the ship — exponential graph, point-of-no-return line visibly approaching

95-H03-A — Three system statements in large format: STABILITY REQUIRED · VARIABLES INTERFERE · RESOLUTION PENDING